

FEAST 2026 Keynote - Tory Sampson

Title: Non-iconic outcomes from iconic motivations in sign languages: Movement repetition in novel noun-verb pairs

Abstract: Analyses of nominal movement repetition in noun-verb pairs have drawn on a variety of theoretical and methodological approaches (Supalla & Newport, 1978; Wilcox, 2004; Kimmelman, 2009; Tkachman & Sandler, 2013; Berent et al., 2014; Abner, 2017; Abner et al., 2019), however, explanations for how and why this pattern emerged in multiple unrelated sign languages remain elusive. Nominal movement repetition has been argued to be iconic (Johnston, 2003), however, experimental work shows that it is not transparently iconic to hearing non-signers (Pyers & Emmorey, 2022), leading to a need for theoretical consolidation between the propensity of movement to originate from iconic motivations and the non-iconic status of nominal movement repetition. Because the cognitive and linguistic mechanisms underpinning its emergence still remain unclear, I will present a series of “wug test” experiments that investigate the role of movement, repetition, and the interaction between iconicity and modality in the emergence of noun-verb pairs. By presenting novel objects and actions to both deaf signers and hearing non-signers, I show how the interaction between modality and two distinct iconic principles, atomicity and “movement as action” embodiment, creates a tension that gives rise to non-iconic nominal movement repetition. These findings furthermore have important implications for our understanding of cross-modal typological patterns of reduplication and repetition in signed and spoken languages.